

on an account; employment considerations; insurance underwriting; a potential partnership; security clearance; or lease. Reports may also be issued at the written request of the consumer or a court.

How private is your private information?

Basically, the feds say it is okay for lots of people to be taking a peek at your credit report. They are only supposed to do so in order to make a determination regarding you and your creditworthiness. The usual suspects are: landlords, current and potential; employers, current and potential; insurance companies; child support enforcement agencies; government agencies (because they are the government); an identity theft monitoring company (obviously – only if you hired them to do it); and of course, any potential lenders. And your mama.

Wow, that is quite a list; and that last listed item is just to see if you were paying attention. Your private information has the ability to be seen by a lot of eyes, but your mother has no legal right to it, unless you give her written permission.

Every time someone inquires about your credit, it impacts your credit score. That is unless a soft inquiry is made – like by a credit card company targeting you for business. If the number of credit card offers that arrive in our mailboxes every day are any indication, these kinds of soft inquiries are happening very frequently!

Got All That?

Every single thing you do with your credit cards, your car loans, your student loans, your home mortgage loans, any bank loans, is all reported by the credit companies to the credit reporting agencies. They do just that – report your credit.

It seems like everybody is able to see your credit report, but most of us have not seen our own. If the banks and the credit card companies are looking at your credit report every day in order to mess with your interest rate, it is important for you to understand your credit report too.